Belgium: energy security, economic opportunity and partnership priorities

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AI-generated from the data and checked against it; paper baseline as of 12 October 2026.

Summary

- Belgium is most exposed in midstream batteries, upstream coal and upstream oil, where its Energy Security is higher than only 8%, 19% and 20% of the other economies scored. Its midstream battery sector has no recorded investment, and fuel production falls short of consumption.[1]
- Its strongest openings are in upstream gas, midstream oil and midstream gas, where its Economic Opportunity is higher than 88%, 87% and 86% of the other economies scored, mainly on the strength of its trade.[1]
- On the paper's weighting, the Strategic Index puts downstream solar 1st among Belgium's own sectors, almost tied with upstream wind; current policy activity places it in the group with the most policy.[1]
- The Partnership Strength Index rates France highest for Belgium, as a reliable supplier; it is also Belgium's 3rd trade partner, while China, its 8th, ranks 35th on Partnership Strength.[1,2]

1. Energy security risks and why

9 of Belgium's 30 placed sectors, those where both scores can be compared with other economies, sit in the two low-energy-security corners. Compared with other economies in each sector, its Energy Security is lowest in midstream batteries, upstream coal, upstream oil and downstream solar, all in the Upgrade corner. It is higher than only 8%, 19%, 20% and 22% of the other 53, 95, 96 and 147 economies scored, with scores of 0.29, 0.26, 0.37 and 0.44. The paper's framework associates that corner, which pairs high opportunity with low energy security, with building domestic capability.[1]

The data mark downstream solar, midstream batteries and upstream batteries as its high-priority sectors. In midstream batteries, the score is low mainly because of investment and trade. Its investment score is 0.00 against a median of 0.25: no investment or manufacturing capacity is recorded, which the index counts as zero. Its trade deficit in these goods was 0.4% of GDP in 2023. In downstream solar, reserves pull the score down: on solar resource potential, Belgium scores higher than only 2% of the other economies.[1,3]

In upstream coal and upstream oil, import needs pull the score down. Production minus consumption was -0.121 EJ for coal and -1.18 EJ for oil in 2025. Both figures take production from the U.S. Energy Information Administration's international statistics, as the Energy Institute does not report it separately. No oil reserves are recorded, which the index counts as zero.[4,5]

For context, its largest suppliers in midstream batteries in 2024 were China (21.3% of imports, which totalled USD 2.48 bn), the Netherlands (15.4%) and Hungary (15.1%). In upstream oil, the Netherlands supplied 77.3% of its imports.[2]

2. Economic opportunities and why

27 of the 30 placed sectors sit in the two high-opportunity corners, where Economic Opportunity is above the sector's middle economy. Compared with other economies in each sector, its Economic Opportunity is highest in upstream gas, midstream oil and midstream gas. It is higher than 88%, 87% and 86% of the other 97, 155 and 155 economies scored, with scores of 0.52, 0.64 and 0.61. Of these, upstream gas sits in the Upgrade corner and the others in the Grow corner.[1]

Trade pushes the score up most in each of these sectors. In upstream gas, Belgium reported exports of USD 9.84 bn in 2024, with a revealed comparative advantage of 1.54. On export feasibility, which reads related capabilities, it scores higher than 99% of the other economies. For context, on the reconciled trade data, France took 95.4% of its exports in this sector in 2024.[1,2,6]

In midstream oil and midstream gas, trade and cost competitiveness push the score up. Belgium reported exports of USD 1.78 bn and USD 1.8 bn in 2024. On input costs of labour and capital, Belgium scores higher than 66% of the other economies in each.[1,6]

Among the high-priority sectors, downstream solar has Economic Opportunity higher than 80% of the other 147 economies scored. Cost competitiveness and investment push it up: on annual investment it scores higher than 81% of the other economies.[1]

3. Sectoral priorities and the existing policy posture

The Strategic Index ranks a country's own sectors by combining opportunity, security need, policy activity, the supply-chain stage and the technology's low-emission value. On the paper's weighting, it puts downstream solar 1st, upstream wind 2nd, upstream nuclear 3rd, upstream solar 4th and midstream batteries 5th among Belgium's own sectors. The leader, downstream solar, scores 0.66, only 0.002 ahead of the next, so they are almost tied; the next gaps, 0.006 and 0.004, also count as almost tied. Its policy term adds 0.200; without that term it falls into the middle third of sectors.[1]

The allied pick, the leading upstream or midstream sector after a screen for a resource base, is midstream batteries (0.63), 0.014 ahead of midstream solar. The screen leaves out upstream wind, upstream nuclear and upstream solar because no resource base is recorded for them.[7]

Comparing priority, the index without its policy term, with policy activity, upstream solar, upstream wind and midstream batteries combine top priority with the most policy. No top-priority sector falls in the group with the least policy, and no bottom-priority sector in the group with the most. The sectors with bottom priority and the least policy are upstream oil, midstream gas, upstream coal, midstream coal, midstream oil, downstream oil and downstream coal. Belgium carries the Climate Action Tracker rating Insufficient (November 2024) and has 187 records in the International Energy Agency's Policies and Measures database, 98 of which name a technology.[1,8,9]

4. Partnership priorities and why

The Partnership Strength Index rates partners as suppliers (Friendshore), as markets for exports (Partnership Opportunity) and, for middle- and lower-income partners, by Development Potential. From Belgium's viewpoint it ranks France 1st, Italy 2nd, the United Kingdom 3rd, the Netherlands 4th and Spain 5th of 193 partners. France and Italy stand out most as a reliable supplier; Italy's best sectors as a supplier are downstream solar, downstream batteries, midstream nuclear, upstream wind and upstream batteries. The

United Kingdom, the Netherlands and Spain stand out most as an export market; the Netherlands' best sectors as a market are midstream wind, upstream coal, upstream electric vehicles, midstream batteries and upstream batteries.[1]

These priorities match today's ties. The Netherlands is Belgium's 1st trade partner on average across its energy-goods baskets, France its 3rd, Italy its 4th, Spain its 6th and the United Kingdom its 7th. Each is a priority partner with strong ties today, shares membership of NATO with Belgium and votes in the same bloc as Belgium at the UN. Germany, its 2nd trade partner, ranks 6th on Partnership Strength. By contrast, China is its 8th trade partner but ranks 35th, and they vote in opposite blocs at the UN.[1,2,10,11]

As a partner to the coalition, Belgium ranks 8th of 192 economies, on Partnership Strength averaged over the core members' viewpoints. In the allied network design, which spreads production of each upstream and midstream sector across coalition members, its largest designed share is 0.7% of midstream green hydrogen.[1,7]

5. Data notes and caveats

Country Insights shows these values as of 12 October 2026. Scores compare Belgium with other economies in the same sector; they are not measures of risk or profit in absolute terms. All index values are the paper's baseline as of 12 October 2026; Strategic Insights recomputes them under other weightings. Strategic Index scores within 0.01 of each other are almost tied: small changes in the data or the weights can swap their order. Some figures behind these scores are filled in where the source has no value: with zero where a source lists every holder, otherwise with the world average. Many allied picks are close calls: in the paper, 37% of them are within 0.01 of the runner-up. In the allied network design the European Union is one producer; Belgium's shares are derived from its weight within the EU. The Climate Action Tracker rates the EU as a whole; Belgium carries the EU's rating. Belgium's counts leave out the EU's own 438 International Energy Agency policy records. Trade figures count trade with other EU members.

Sources

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